Republics were called sub-federations within the Soviet Federation and the USSR was called a 'Federation of Federations'.

5. Parliamentary Government The Constitution provided for a parliamentary form of Government in the USSR. The Council of Ministers was elected by the Supreme Soviet (legislature of the USSR) and remained responsible to it for its policies and acts. The Supreme Soviet could also remove the Ministers from their offices. The Constitution stated that 'the Council of Ministers headed by the Premier is the highest executive and administrative authority of the USSR'.

6. Bicameralism The Constitution provided for a bicameral legislature for the USSR. Thus, the Supreme Soviet consisted of the Soviet of the Union (lower House) and the Soviet of the Nationalities (upper House). Both the houses had equal number of members (i.e. 750 in each) elected directly every five years. The lower House represented the nation as a whole while the upper House represented the units of the Soviet Federation. The two Houses had equal and coordinated powers in all policy matters.

7. Presidium The Supreme Soviet, constitutionally the highest body of state authority of the USSR, elected a governing body known as the Presidium. The Constitution termed it as the Standing Committee of the Supreme Soviet. It was a 39-member body consisting of a Chairman, First Vice-Chairman, 15 Vice Chairmen (i.e. the heads of the 15 Union Republics), a Secretary and 21 members. The Chairman (President) of the Presidium was the formal head of the State of the USSR. It functioned as a collective presidency of the USSR. Hence it was called the 'Collegial Executive' or the 'Plural Executive' or the 'Collegiate President' of the USSR. It combined executive, legislative, diplomatic, military and judicial functions. Because of its multifarious functions and the plural character, the Presidium of the Supreme Soviet of the USSR has been described as the '20th Century Innovation.' This type of institution was not provided by any other Constitution of the world.

8. One-Party Dictatorship The most important feature of the constitutional system of the USSR was the monopoly of the political power enjoyed by the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU). The Soviet Constitution stated, 'the leading and guiding force of Soviet Society and the nucleus of its political system, of all state organisations and public organisations is the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. The CPSU exists for the people and serves the people. The Communist Party, armed with Marxism-Leninism, determines the general perspectives of the development of society and the course of home and foreign policy of the USSR, directs the great constructive work of the Soviet people and imparts a planned, systematic and theoretically substantiated character to their struggle for the victory of communism'.

9. Democratic Centralism The Constitution stated that 'the Soviet state is organised and functions on the principle of democratic centralism, namely the electiveness of all bodies of state authority from the lowest to the highest, their accountability to the people and the obligation of lower bodies to observe the decisions of higher ones. Democratic centralism combines central leadership with local initiative and creative activity and with the responsibility of each state body and official for the work entrusted to them'. This principle was applicable to governmental organisation; hierarchy of the Soviets and the Communist Party organisation.

10. Fundamental Rights The Constitution also provided for a large number of economic, social, personal, cultural and political rights to the citizens of the USSR. These rights were guaranteed to all the citizens of the country equally irrespective of nationality, race, sex, and so on. The form of the rights granted to the citizens was socialist, not personal, that is they were meant for the establishment of a socialist system in